UNDERGROUND U20

THE EVIDENCE GAP | Independent football recruitment research | 28 October 2026

EXECUTIVE FINDING

A player can be promising, visible, and contractually protected at the same time. Talent alone is not a scouting opportunity. This research replaces overconfident Top-10 lists with a traceable evidence-to-decision workflow.

THE CASE: BENJAMIN NICOLAISEN, VEJLE U19

5	235	3 / 2	1
OFFICIAL REPORTS	EST. REGULATION MINUTES	STARTS / SUBSTITUTE APPS	GOALS IN SAMPLE

Five specifically identified match reports, not complete season coverage. Minutes are calculated with 90-minute caps. Sources include Vejle official fixture reports dated 22 Aug, 5 Sep, 12 Sep, 19 Sep and 9 Oct 2026. The club announced a contract extension through the end of 2028.

RECONSTRUCTED MATCH LEDGER

DATE	OPPONENT	USAGE	MIN
2026-08-22	AC Horsens	START	46
2026-09-05	AGF	SUB	21
2026-09-12	Silkeborg IF	START	55
2026-09-19	HB Køge	SUB	32
2026-10-09	Esbjerg fB	START	81

THE NEGATIVE FINDING

This is not an established undervalued transfer target. The 2028 contract and documented youth international exposure are counterevidence to a low-exposure acquisition claim. The appropriate action is OBSERVE / BENCHMARK, not BUY.

METHOD: EVIDENCE BEFORE SCORES

Original research protocol - not yet a validated predictive model.

1. Identify position from first-party evidence; flag conflicts. 2. Recover dated deployment information and record exact source URLs. 3. Calculate performance rates only with trustworthy denominators. 4. Separate sporting signal from visibility and contract protection. 5. Report disconfirming evidence and the next investigation action.

RESEARCH DECISION MATRIX

PLAYER	GATE	EVIDENCE STATUS
Benjamin Nicolaisen	OBSERVE / BENCHMARK	5 first-party reports; partial playing-time evidence
Dinis Leite	INVESTIGATE	Official LW designation; reliable minutes missing
Cadriano Marsh	INVESTIGATE	Club listing; role / usage unresolved
Nicolas Gammelgaard	BENCHMARK	Already visible senior-transition prospect

WHAT WE DID NOT DO

No full-match video was reviewed. No player-level dribbling grade or tactical quality score is claimed. No complete 2026/27 U19 season database was obtained. No validated market valuation, predictive machine-learning model, transfer feasibility, or comparative advantage over a baseline has been demonstrated.

WHAT A CLUB CAN DO WITH THIS RELEASE

Use the report as a transparent investigation queue: request full match footage, verify the complete season and role, obtain current contract information, and submit independent observation notes before any recruitment recommendation.

FULL PRIMARY SOURCES & REPRODUCIBILITY

See docs/SOURCES.md for direct official links, data/verified_match_ledger.csv for individual dates and substitutions, and src/reproduce_ledger.py for recalculation. All listed first-party material is credited; no copyrighted match imagery is reproduced.

Historical Wyscout 2017/18 data is an independent software-validation lab only: DOI 10.6084/m9.figshare.c.4415000 (CC BY 4.0). Its results are NOT evidence about 2026 U19 players.

RESEARCH STATUS

FINAL PUBLICATION-READY RESEARCH RELEASE / INVESTIGATIVE SCOPE. This is not a completed professional transfer shortlist. Recommendations would require additional data and systematic video validation.